

Syncopation and swing

Syncopated rhythms tend to cross the beat, or are accented in a way that contradicts the beat. Syncopated music often uses ties or rests on the main beats, creating a more energetic kind of rhythm.

SEE ALSO

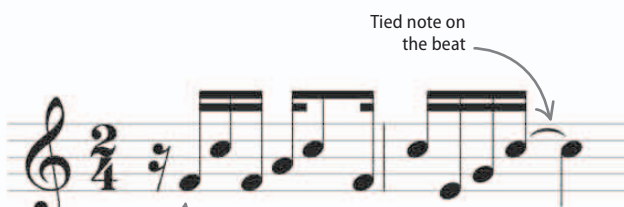
◀ 30–31 Time signatures

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Ragtime

A classic example of a syncopated style, ragtime is typically written in a steady 2/4 or 4/4 time, but with many melody notes held across the beat, which is marked emphatically in the bass line. It became popular in the early 20th century, especially through the compositions of Scott Joplin (c.1868–1917).



Off beat start to the tune

Tied note on the beat

△ **"Maple Leaf Rag"**
Shown here are the first two measures of "Maple Leaf Rag" by Scott Joplin. The right-hand tune shows some typical rhythmic features of ragtime.

Calypso

Calypso is another style that often syncopates across the beat. Calypso songs usually use an irregular division of the 4/4 beat, a 3 + 3 + 2 division of the eight eighth notes. Originally from West Africa, this type of rhythm is widespread in Caribbean and Latin-American music.

Measuring in eighth notes, this is 3 + 3 + 2



4/4

▽ Irregular division

The stressed notes in this example are in a 3 + 3 + 2 rhythm cut across the normal beat accents of a straight 4/4 meter.

▽ "Linstead Market"

This Jamaican folk song features syncopated rhythms, typical of Caribbean music. The tied notes in the first and third measures cross the third beat, making a 3 + 3 + 2 rhythm.



Syncopations